

9Marks and catholicity

Their catholicity and ours, side by side.

What is commendable, what is missing, and what the word requires.

“That they all may be one; as thou, Father, art in me, and I in thee, that they also may be one in us: that the world may believe that thou hast sent me.” (John 17:21)

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What catholicity asks of 9Marks

The honor owed first

9Marks is a ministry founded around Mark Dever, pastor of Capitol Hill Baptist Church in Washington, and led today by Jonathan Leeman. It exists to promote nine marks of a healthy church, expository preaching, biblical theology, the gospel, conversion, evangelism, membership, discipline, discipleship, and a plurality of elders, and Tim Challies, the most read Reformed blogger of his generation, has been its friendly popularizer for twenty years. In 2023 the ministry devoted an entire issue of its journal to catholicity, and its editor called the effort a reclamation project: to breathe life back into a word evangelical pastors greet with raised eyebrows.

Say the honor plainly before anything is weighed, because it is real and it is owed. In an evangelical world of church-growth technique and celebrity pulpits, 9Marks has spent decades arguing that a church is a defined people and not an audience, that membership means something, that discipline is love, that the pulpit exists to say what the text says. Those instincts

are not merely good, they are ancient, and this site has argued every one of them from the first millennium's own documents. More striking still, these men teach their churches to recite the Creed of 381 and to confess one holy catholic and apostolic church while meaning it. And they picked up the word. Of all the words evangelicalism left in the attic, they went and got the one this whole site is about, on purpose, against their own market's instincts. Two reclamation projects are now working on the same word, and this page exists because the word deserves to know which of them finishes the job.

The two questions

Every ministry is an answer to some question, and the fastest way to weigh two answers is to name the two questions. The question 9Marks asks is this: given that gospel-preaching congregations are separate, and will remain separate, how should they recognize one another and work together for the Great Commission without compromising their convictions? It is a real question, asked in good faith, and their answer, spelled out in Dever's own charge to pastors, is genuinely useful: pray for the church down the street, swap pulpits, send members who move away to the like-minded congregation near their new home, plant together, speak well of one another, keep the partnerships as thick as the agreement is. Leeman gives the whole program in three words, churches partnering together.

The question this site asks is different, and the difference is the whole matter. Given that the Lord prayed for a oneness the world can see, and given that the whole Church of the first millennium visibly had it, what would it cost each communion, by name, to have it again? Notice what the two questions assume. Theirs assumes the divisions as weather, permanent conditions under which love must operate. Ours treats the divisions as wounds, and asks which ones the whole Church ever agreed to and what it would take to close them. Their question produces a manners manual for life among the walls, and it is a good manners manual. Our question produces a survey of the walls themselves, which ones the whole Church built, which ones one part built alone, and which ones nobody bound at all, the survey the charting papers spend three parts conducting. Both questions are askable. Only one of them is the question the word catholicity was coined to answer.

What they did to the word

Leeman's definitional essay begins exactly where this site begins. Catholic, he writes, derives from kata and holos, with respect to the whole, and the Roman claim to own the word is, in his own fine phrase, ironically uncatholic. So far, one project. Then comes the turn, and it should be quoted rather than summarized: the local gathering, he writes, is what we behold with the

eyes of flesh, a manifestation or outpost of something we can only behold with the eyes of faith, namely, the catholic or universal church. Read that twice. The whole, the holos the word points at, is defined as invisible in the act of defining it. Whatever is visible is local, and whatever is whole cannot be seen. From that single move everything else follows, because if the only visible church is the congregation, then catholicity can only ever be a relation between congregations, and the imperative falls out just as he states it: recognize and partner with other gospel-preaching churches as occasion allows. Partnership is what catholicity has to become for a man whose ecclesiology has nothing visible left to unite.

And the fifth point of his definition says the quiet part with admirable candor: a right doctrine of catholicity, Leeman writes, is Protestant, for it roots in a shared view of the gospel, not in a shared view of the ordinances or church structure. There it is, stated as doctrine: the sacraments and the ministry, two of the things the whole Church actually held everywhere, always, and by all, are excluded from the basis of catholicity by definition. St. Vincent's three tests have been reduced to one test, and the one test is agreement about justification. Dever's own long essay, the most historically serious piece in the issue, shows he knows precisely what was traded. He quotes Ignatius, where Jesus Christ is, there is the universal church. He states, correctly, that from the second century to the modern period the word catholic was a term of definition and exclusion, marking the regular from the irregular. He cites the Vincentian canon in full, everywhere, always, and by all. And then he reports, approvingly, that Luther and Calvin gave primacy to the always, redefining catholic as a category about time rather than space, so that catholicity among Protestants, he concludes, has seemed very much like apostolicity, tied to no place, no kingdom, and no succession. That is not a slander of their position. It is their position, stated by their own best historian: of Vincent's three knives they kept one, and even that one now cuts to their own pattern, for a church that believes the whole visible Church fell into error about the Supper and the ministry for a thousand years has not kept the always either. The canon of Scripture they trust came down the very channel the definition just closed.

The walls, and the hands shaken over them

The journal's triage essay commends J.C. Ryle's counsel, keep the walls of separation as low as possible, and shake hands over them as often as you can. It is a warm sentence and everyone has felt its warmth, but stand back from it and look at what it grants. The walls stay. Lowering and hand-shaking are the whole program, and the essay around the quotation is a sorting method, sectarian or catholic, faithful or accommodating, for deciding which walls to shake hands over and which to build higher. Another essay in the issue warns against catholicity as a vehicle of compromise and, discussing why a Baptist church and a Presbyterian church rightly remain separate, lands on this sentence: we can happily pray that their church grows and holds

fast to the gospel, even as we recognize that it's a good thing our church isn't collapsed into theirs. A good thing. The division itself, blessed as prudence. And the triage essay approvingly quotes the claim that evangelical Protestantism, with all its denominational diversity, actually represents a far more impressive model of true unity than does the Church of Rome, which is the argument at its most honest: the diversity of separated denominations is not the problem catholicity exists to heal, it is presented as the achievement.

This is the place to say the hard sentence, and to say it without contempt, because these are brothers and the page has already said so. A unity that is invisible by definition, that blesses the walls as good things, that costs no church one binding and no pastor one structure, and that can never be seen by anyone standing outside it, is not the thing the first millennium meant by the word. It is friendship among the separated. Friendship among the separated is better than enmity among the separated, and this site will take it over the alternative every day of the week. But the Creed those churches recite does not say one holy friendly and apostolic. The word in the Creed was coined by men for whom the whole Church was a public fact, one altar in each city, bishops who carried letters of communion across the empire, councils whose decrees bound churches that had never been in the room, a communion a man could be received into and put out of. When that is what the word carries, reclaiming the word means reclaiming the thing. What 9Marks has reclaimed, so far, is the spelling.

The rail test

Every definition meets a test case, and the journal, to its credit, does not hide its own. Leeman opens his longest essay with a story against himself: visiting a Missouri Synod Lutheran congregation, he reads in the bulletin that he, a baptized Christian and president of a ministry devoted to catholicity, may not receive the Supper there. He tells the story to be fair to the Lutherans, and the essay then defends the same boundary from the other side, for his own church requires believer's baptism for membership, which means a Presbyterian elder, baptized in infancy and gray in the service of Christ, cannot join Cheverly Baptist Church without being baptized again. The essay's whole labor is to show that such barring is compatible with catholic affirmation, and within their definitions the argument is coherent. But step outside the definitions and look at the scene. Here is a catholicity in which the partner churches cannot seat one another's members at the Supper or receive them into membership, in which the sign of unity is precisely the thing the unity cannot include. The partnering is real, the conferences are warm, the pulpits are swapped, and the Supper is fenced against the partners. This site keeps the same rule for everyone, and it said of Rome's closed altar that the cost is an argument for

healing the division, not for pretending it is healed. The identical sentence now falls here. The ache Leeman felt at the Lutheran rail was the correct response, and it is the strongest page in the whole journal. The system he defends exists so that nobody ever has to feel it again.

The nine marks and the four

The Creed their churches recite gives the Church four marks: one, holy, catholic, and apostolic. The ministry's nine marks are expository preaching, biblical theology, the gospel, conversion, evangelism, membership, discipline, discipleship, and leadership. Set the lists side by side and count the overlap. None of the four made the nine. Unity is not a mark of a healthy church. Catholicity is not a mark of a healthy church, in the ministry named for the marks, which is presumably why the journal's editor concedes the word draws quizzical looks from the very pastors the ministry has been forming for thirty years. Holiness appears, if at all, as discipleship, and apostolicity as expository preaching, which is apostolicity reduced to the apostles' documents with the apostles' order and rite set aside.

And one absence was caught at the time by the movement's own friend. Tim Challies, in the very post that introduced 9Marks to his readers in 2004, laid the nine beside the Reformation's three marks of a true church, word, discipline, and sacraments, and wrote plainly: glaringly absent, then, is the emphasis on the proper administration of the sacraments. He even recorded Dever's answer, that most churches still place sufficient emphasis on the sacraments, so it is not a lost mark in need of recovery, and then, gently, refused it, noting that the Supper in evangelical churches is deferred, thinned, and sometimes removed from the service lest it trouble the seekers. Challies was right, and twenty years of church practice have vindicated him. The Supper the Lord commanded, the act Ignatius called the medicine of immortality, the thing the first Christians assembled to do on the first day of the week, is not among the nine marks of a healthy church, and the explanation offered is that it is sufficiently emphasized already. Ninety years after Paul, a pagan governor could describe the Christians' fixed day and their meal. A visitor to the healthiest of healthy churches today could attend for a month and never see it.

What they fear, and what actually answers it

Be fair to the fear, because the fear is the most defensible thing in the whole system. The journal's cautionary tale is Billy Graham, traced with receipts through four decades, the growing catholic resolve that led him to platform men who denied the atonement, to share services he should not have shared, and at last, in old age, to suggest that men who do not know the name of Jesus may be saved believers anyway. That is a true story and a terrible one, and

every warning the journal draws from it is warranted. These men have watched the word unity do exactly one thing in their lifetimes: dissolve the gospel. The only catholicity on offer in their world has been the liberal ecumenism of the mainline, unity purchased by indifference, and against that they have chosen truth over togetherness, and they chose correctly.

But the choice itself is the false alternative, and the first millennium is the proof. The undivided Church was not the tolerant option. She was the most doctrinally exacting institution in human history, a communion that wrote the creeds, condemned the heresies by name, deposed bishops over one word, and fenced her altar against the unbaptized and the unrepentant, and she did all of it as one visible body. Her unity did not dilute her doctrine. Her unity is what gave her doctrine teeth, for a church that can excommunicate across the whole world is the only kind that can define anything at all. That is the option the Graham story never offers: a unity more binding than 9Marks, not less. Mere catholicity does not ask these churches to hold their convictions loosely. It asks them to notice that the faith of the first millennium, creed, font, Supper, order, was bound harder than any Baptist statement of faith has ever bound anything, and that reception by the whole Church, the standard this site's book defends at length, is the exact opposite of doctrinal indifference. It is doctrine with a court. Their system protects the gospel from false unity by keeping every church its own final judge. The ancient system protected it by binding the whole, which is why their gospel still exists for them to protect.

The council they cite

Leeman's essay lists Acts 15 among the catholic texts, and so it is, but watch what it is cited for, the principle that the church is built on nothing but Christ. True. Now read what happens in the chapter. The apostles and elders gather in one city, debate, and issue a decree, and as they went through the cities, they delivered them the decrees for to keep, that were ordained of the apostles and elders. Churches that were not in the room were bound by churches that were. The one undisputed instance of catholicity in action inside the New Testament is a council whose decisions traveled with authority, and it is the one thing the 9Marks system can never produce, because in their polity nobody may bind anybody. Their catholicity has greetings, collections, and partnerships, and so did the first century's, but the first century's also had the decree, and the second century had the rule of faith, and the fourth had Nicaea, and the instrument was the same in every case: the churches acting as one visible body whose word was binding because it was the word of the whole. What 9Marks calls partnering, the first millennium called communion, and communion had organs, the synod, the letter of communion, the shared altar, the common creed. Partnership is communion with the organs removed, and the verses page of

this site's second charting paper has already made the argument in full: the honest low-church reading of the New Testament buys presbyterianism at most, and it never bought the rented room.

That the world may believe

Both projects quote the same prayer, so let the prayer judge between them. That they all may be one, as thou, Father, art in me, and I in thee, that they also may be one in us: that the world may believe that thou hast sent me. The petition has a purpose clause, and the purpose clause is the whole difference. The oneness the Lord asks for is the kind the world can see, for it is offered as evidence to people who do not believe, and the world cannot weigh evidence it cannot perceive. An invisible unity, beheld only with the eyes of faith, is by its own definition invisible to the world, which means it cannot do the one thing the prayer says the oneness is for. And the unity of the Father and the Son, the prayer's own standard, is no federation of the like-minded who remain wisely uncollapsed into one another. What the world actually sees, looking at Protestant America, is the strip mall this site's second paper begins in, five churches in one parking lot, each with its own statement of faith, none in communion with any other, all partnering warmly. The world has seen the partnering for a century, and the world has drawn its conclusion, and the conclusion is not that the Father sent the Son. It is that Christians cannot agree about him. Cooperation is invisible at the distance unbelief stands at. Communion is visible from across an empire, which is how a persecuted minority of fishermen and slaves convinced one, holy, catholic Rome that God had done something new in the world.

What catholicity asks of 9Marks

The site's rule is that every ask must be mutual and every door left open, so here is the ask, offered in the same spirit their journal offers its counsel. Keep all nine marks. Every one of them is a recovered piece of the ancient discipline, and the churches that practice them are healthier than the churches that do not. Then add the four the Creed already put in their mouths. Let unity be a mark of health, so that a church content with permanent separation is judged as needing recovery in the same breath as a church without discipline. Let catholicity mean what Dever's own history shows it meant, the whole visible Church, so that the partnerships already built become the scaffolding of communion rather than its substitute. Seat the Supper among the marks, weekly, at the center, where the first day of the week has kept it since the year the documents begin, and let the ache of the fenced rail be felt rather than solved. Let the triage become reception, for triage ranks doctrines in order to live with division, and reception weighs them in order to end it, and the retrieval movement the journal's own book reviews commend, Baptists reaching back toward creeds and fathers, is this road already walked to its first bend.

None of this asks a single church to hold a conviction loosely. It asks the convictions to be carried to the council, the way Acts 15 carried circumcision, and argued there before the whole, which is what convictions were for. The first millennium is not the property of Rome, and setting Rome's later claims down is half this site's work. The other half is this page's: the whole Church's faith is not the property of the local congregation either, and a reclamation project that stops at partnership has reclaimed the word from Rome only to bind it to the parish. Finish the reclamation. The word means the whole. Come take the whole.

The charting papers grade every communion on the same nine rows, the free churches by the same rule as Rome, and the fifty objections a free-church reader brings are answered one by one. This page ends where every page of this site ends, at the same prayer both projects claim, and the reader may judge which project takes it at its word: that they all may be one, that the world may believe (John 17:21).

Quod ubique, quod semper, quod ab omnibus.

Scripture quotations are from the King James Version unless otherwise noted.